STRIKING A FINE BALANCE

India has to continue its robust diplomacy—balance strategic ties with partners, speak up for global justice and pave the way for economic progress

BY PRADIP R. SAGAR

Foreign policy has been regarded as an area of success for the Narendra Modi–led NDA government since 2014—a sign of a confident India asserting itself on the global stage. No passage of events proved it more effectively than how New Delhi steered deep functional ties with both the United States and Russia, without one jeopardising the other. Its presidency of the G20 also saw India renew its old role as a leading voice of the Global South. New Delhi's diplomatic skills were again on view this February, when the ministry secured a pardon for eight former Indian naval officers held on death row in Qatar. Closer home, as Pakistan extended an olive branch on the occasion of Modi's oath-taking on June 9, India stayed firm on its stand of peace being contingent on cessation of terror.

India's ties with Russia, an old ally and a major source of energy, are seemingly at odds with its growing strategic alliance with the US. Balancing 'principles' with 'interests', India resisted US-NATO pressure to condemn Russia at the UN. In late 2023, external affairs minister Jaishankar visited Moscow to reaffirm "strong and steady" ties, signing deals on trade, energy, security and a nuclear plant. While relations with Nepal, Bangladesh, Bhutan, Sri Lanka and Myanmar are under control, Maldives along with Pakistan is the only other nation with an 'unfriendly' posture. The BJP's manifesto also talks about preparing the diplomatic groundwork for the Maritime India Vision (SAGAR) and the India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC) to promote India's trade interests. ■

S. JAISHANKAR, *69* | BJP
Minister of External Affairs

↘ Shaping policy Born and raised in Delhi, Jaishankar was educated in St Stephen's College and JNU, joined the IFS in 1977 and was foreign secretary from 2015-2018. A new recruit to the BJP, he was made external affairs minister in 2019

↘ Strengthening ties Jaishankar has focused on strengthening India's ties with major powers like the US, Russia and European countries, while deepening engagement in the neighbourhood and partners in the Indo-Pacific region

↘ Proactive diplomacy That was the hallmark of his first stint. It included efforts to enhance India's influence in forums like the G20 and BRICS. Jaishankar plays a key role in promoting India's economic/ security interests in a complex, interconnected world

↘ A First Jaishankar was the second diplomat to become a foreign minister (Natwar Singh was the first), but the first former foreign secretary to lead the ministry

Ministers of State



PABITRA MARGHERITA, *49* | BJP

An artful addition
Margherita comes from the industrial town of Margherita in Tinsukia district of Assam. A BJP member of the Rajya Sabha, he was once editor of two cultural magazines



KIRTI VARDHAN SINGH, *58* | BJP

Royalty in the mix
A five-term Lok Sabha MP of the BJP from Gonda in UP—and thus experienced in governance and public service—Kirti Vardhan Singh hails from the royal family of Mankapur